

COMPLETE UNIT

KS3: Causes of the Great War



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: How did decades of imperial rivalry and fear culminate in thirty days of madness?

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THE GERMAN REICH

1871-1918

This map illustrates the territorial composition of the German Reich during its imperial era. The empire's borders are highlighted in red, encompassing a vast area from the North Sea to the Black Sea and from the Swiss Alps to the Baltic coast. The map is color-coded to distinguish between different administrative regions and neighboring states.

Legend:

- FHZ = Fürstentum Hohenzollern (zu Preußen)
- LD = Fürstentum Lippe
- OLD = zu Großherzogtum Oldenburg
- RÄL = Fürstentum Reuß ältere Linie
- RJL = Fürstentum Reuß jüngere Linie
- SA = Herzogtum Sachsen-Altenburg
- SCG = Herzogtum Sachsen-Coburg und Gotha
- SL = Fürstentum Schaumburg-Lippe
- SMG = Herzogtum Sachsen-Meiningen
- SR = Fürstentum Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt
- SWE = Großherzogtum Sachsen-Weimar-Eisenach
- W = Fürstentum Waldeck und Pyrmont (Landesteil Pyrmont)



L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand how Otto von Bismarck used 'blood and iron' to unify the German states.
- ☐ Analyze the geographical impact of the new German Empire on the balance of power in Europe.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle *ONE* term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Chancellor | Blood and Iron

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Today, Germany is one of the most powerful and successful industrial countries in Europe. But if you looked at a map of Europe in 1800, you would not find a country called "Germany" at all. Instead, you would see a messy patchwork of hundreds of small, independent states. In this lesson, you will discover the remarkable story of how a brilliant, ruthless statesman used "blood and iron" to crush his neighbours, unite these states, and create a brand-new superpower that would completely change the history of the world.

At the start of the 19th century, the German-speaking people were divided. In 1800, there were around 400 separate states making up what was known as the Holy Roman Empire, each with its own independent ruler. Following the Napoleonic Wars, these states were simplified and reduced to 39 states, forming a loose grouping known as the German Confederation in 1815. Within this Confederation, the two largest and most powerful states—the Catholic empire of Austria and the militaristic kingdom of Prussia—constantly competed with each other for leadership. In 1834, Prussia gained a massive economic advantage by setting up a free-trade customs union called the *Zollverein*. By removing internal customs barriers while keeping taxes on foreign imports, the *Zollverein* bound the smaller German states economically to Prussia while deliberately excluding Austria. Prussia had won the first round of the battle for dominance.

In 1862, a brilliant and fiercely conservative nobleman named Otto von Bismarck was appointed Chancellor of Prussia. Bismarck had a clear and single-minded goal: to exclude Austria from German affairs once and for all and unite the remaining German states under Prussian leadership. Bismarck despised the slow, democratic methods of speeches and parliaments. In his very first speech as Chancellor, he warned the Prussian parliament of his plans: > *"Germany is not looking to Prussia's liberalism, but to her power... The great questions of the day will not be decided by speeches and resolutions of majorities... but by **blood and iron**."* By "blood," Bismarck meant the lives of soldiers; by "iron," he meant the advanced technology of Prussia's military machine, including its modern railways, artillery, and rapid-firing guns. From the mid-nineteenth century, Prussia built up a massive, exceptionally well-trained, and highly disciplined army. Bismarck was ready to unleash it.

To unite Germany, Bismarck orchestrated three short, decisive wars over a seven-year period: * **War 1: The Danish War (1864)**: Prussia teamed up with Austria to quickly defeat Denmark in a dispute over territory, showing off their military coordination. * **War 2: The Austro-Prussian War (1866)**: Bismarck turned on his former ally, Austria. The modernized Prussian army crushed the Austrian forces in just seven weeks. Following this defeat, Austria was completely excluded from German affairs, leaving Prussia as the undisputed leader of the German states. * **War 3: The Franco-Prussian War (1870–1871)**: To convince the southern German states (who were wary of Prussian dominance) to join his new union, Bismarck needed a common enemy. He cleverly provoked a war with France. The Prussian military machine invaded France, totally destroyed the French armies, and captured the French Emperor.

Having defeated France, Bismarck successfully united the remaining independent northern and southern German states into a single, massive German Empire (the *Kaiserreich*). To add ultimate humiliation to France's defeat, Bismarck arranged for the King of Prussia, Wilhelm I, to be officially proclaimed the first German Emperor (Kaiser) on 18 January 1871 inside the Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles—the historic home of French kings. As part of the peace treaty, Germany also seized Alsace-Lorraine, a highly valuable French industrial region rich in coal and iron. While Germany celebrated its spectacular unification, French citizens looked on with deep bitterness. This land grab created a furious, long-term rivalry between Germany and France that would eventually help spark the First World War forty years later.

Consolidation Task

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Discuss with your partner: Was the German Empire created 'from below' by the people or 'from above' by military force?

Active Tasks

Q2. Was the German Empire forged through master diplomacy or ruthless military aggression?

Q3. Explain how Otto von Bismarck used "blood and iron" and diplomatic calculation to forge the German Empire in 1871.

L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the penalties forced upon France in 1871.
- ☐ Explain how the Ems Telegram sparked the Franco-Prussian War.
- ☐ Evaluate the long-term impact on European relations.

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Chancellor | Blood and Iron | Revanche | Annexation | Indemnity | Two-Front War | North German Confederation | Reinsurance Treaty

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

[1.1] In the late 1860s, Emperor Napoleon III of France watched with growing dread as Prussia eclipsed Austrian influence and unified northern Germany under the North German Confederation. France had long considered itself the supreme military arbiter of mainland Europe. When Queen Isabella II of Spain was deposed in a military revolution in 1868, the provisional Spanish government quietly offered the vacant crown to Prince Leopold of Hohenzollern-Sigmaringen—a Catholic cadet branch of the Prussian royal house. The terrifying prospect of a Hohenzollern monarch reigning on both the Rhine and the Pyrenees provoked near-hysterical outrage in Paris. French foreign minister Antoine de Gramont delivered an incendiary parliamentary speech declaring that France would not permit a foreign power to encircle the nation. Alarmed by the threat of war, Prince Leopold prudently withdrew his candidacy. It was a complete, bloodless diplomatic triumph for France.

[1.2] But Paris was not satisfied with victory; it demanded humiliation. Gramont ordered the French ambassador, Count Vincent Benedetti, to pursue King Wilhelm I of Prussia to the tranquil spa town of Bad Ems. Accosting the elderly monarch on the public garden promenade, Benedetti demanded a binding, written guarantee that no Hohenzollern would ever again accept the Spanish crown. King Wilhelm politely but firmly declined, stating that he could make no such indefinite pledge, and later that afternoon sent a factual telegraphic dispatch of the exchange to Chancellor Otto von Bismarck in Berlin. Bismarck was dining in sullen despondency with General Helmuth von Moltke and War Minister Albrecht von Roon, mourning that a glorious opportunity to unite Germany had slipped away. Reading the King's telegram, Bismarck asked Moltke whether the Prussian army was ready for war. Moltke replied that immediate conflict was vastly preferable to delay. Bismarck picked up his heavy pencil. Without altering or inventing a single word, he ruthlessly struck out the King's polite explanations, condensing the text so that King Wilhelm appeared to have snubbed the French ambassador, and Benedetti appeared to have insulted the Prussian crown. Leaked to the European press on Bastille Day (14 July 1870), the edited **Ems Telegram** acted, in Bismarck's famous phrase, as "a red rag to the Gallic bull." Enraged Parisian crowds marched down the boulevards shouting "*À Berlin!*". On 19 July 1870, France declared war—walking straight into Bismarck's diplomatic snare as the reckless aggressor, which automatically triggered mutual defense treaties binding the independent southern German kingdoms of Bavaria, Württemberg, and Baden to Prussian arms.

[2.1] The French military high command entered the conflict with supreme arrogance, boasting that the Imperial Army would cross the Rhine and dictate peace in Berlin within weeks. French infantry possessed the state-of-the-art *Chassepot* rifle, whose 1,200-meter range far outstripped the Prussian Dreyse needle-gun. Yet French arrogance was instantly crushed by the terrifying efficiency of the Prussian General Staff under Field Marshal Helmuth von Moltke. Mobilizing 380,000 highly disciplined troops across six dedicated railway trunk lines with mathematical precision, the German armies struck with overwhelming speed before French reserves could even find their boots. Crucially, Prussia fielded revolutionary breech-loading cast-steel cannons manufactured by Alfred Krupp. While French bronze muzzle-loaders struggled to fire two rounds a minute with inaccurate time-fuses, Krupp's steel artillery hammered French positions with rapid, pinpoint explosive percussion shells from three miles away. On 1 September 1870 at the **Battle of Sedan**, Moltke trapped the principal French army in a deadly cauldron surrounded by Krupp guns. After enduring 17,000 casualties in hours, Emperor Napoleon III surrendered with 104,000 soldiers, handing his imperial sword to King Wilhelm. The French Second Empire collapsed overnight, and in Paris an angry republic—the Third Republic—was proclaimed, vowing to fight on to the last drop of blood.

[2.2] Rather than capitulating, the desperate French Republic attempted a national people's war. By late September 1870, Prussian armies had encircled Paris, tightening a brutal blockade around two million trapped civilians. For over four agonizing winter months, temperatures plummeted to -12°C. With coal exhausted and food supplies severed, Parisians suffered unspeakable privation. Butcher shops were converted to sell draft horses, then domestic cats and dogs, and eventually butcher stalls sold sewer rats at two francs apiece. In December 1870, the starving capital was reduced to slaughtering the famous pair of elephants, Castor and Pollux, from the Jardin des Plantes zoo to serve luxury restaurants for Christmas. When Krupp siege artillery began hurling shells into civilian residential quarters across the Seine, destroying homes and killing children, French resistance broke. Starving, freezing, and ravaged by smallpox and pneumonia, Paris capitulated on 28 January 1871. Bismarck had utterly shattered the military might of France.

[3.1] The culmination of the war permanently shattered the continental balance of power and inflicted an agonizing humiliation upon the French nation. On 18 January 1871, ten days before Paris officially surrendered, the German princes and generals gathered in the magnificent Hall of Mirrors inside the Palace of Versailles—the historic sanctuary of Louis XIV and French monarchical glory. Surrounding King Wilhelm I, they formally proclaimed the birth of the unified German Empire (the *Kaiserreich*). Staging this imperial triumph on conquered French soil was a deliberate, calculated blow designed to announce Germany's military supremacy to the world. Four months later, under the **Treaty of Frankfurt** (May 1871), Bismarck exacted three crushing penalties: France was compelled to cede the strategic borderland of **Alsace and northern Lorraine** (Source A), pay an astronomical war indemnity of five billion gold francs within three years, and endure a German army of occupation garrisoned on French soil until the final gold coin was delivered.

[3.2] The annexation of Alsace-Lorraine proved to be an insurmountable catastrophe for European peace. By seizing these border provinces, Germany stripped France of 1.5 million French-speaking and German-dialect citizens, vital coalfields, major textile factories, and 80% of France's domestic iron ore reserves. German military engineers rapidly fortified the strategic fortress cities of Metz and Strasbourg, transforming the region into an impregnable military shield protecting the Rhineland. Across France, this territorial amputation generated an all-consuming, institutionalized culture of mourning and vengeance known as *la revanche* (the revenge). In elementary schools across the Third Republic, educational paintings such as Albert Bettannier's *La Tache Noire* (The Black Spot, 1887, Source B) immortalized the classroom ritual: a solemn schoolmaster in a black coat points a wooden wand at Alsace-Lorraine shaded in mourning black on the national map, commanding young boys dressed in paramilitary cadet uniforms never to forget their stolen homeland. In Paris, the statue representing the lost city of Strasbourg in the Place de la Concorde was draped in black mourning crêpe and covered in funeral wreaths continuously until 1918. Politician Léon Gambetta minted France's unyielding national commandment: "*Think of it always; speak of it never.*"

[4.1] Diplomatic historians and military analysts have long debated whether Bismarck's annexation of Alsace-Lorraine was his most brilliant conquest or his most catastrophic strategic blunder. Bismarck himself privately harbored severe doubts about taking Lorraine, warning that annexing a fiercely French-speaking population around Metz would create an incurable sore. However, he was bullied and overruled by Field Marshal von Moltke and the Prussian General Staff, who stubbornly insisted that the fortress of Metz was a military necessity to guard against future French invasion. Eminent diplomatic historian Gordon Craig argued that by yielding to military planners and prioritizing immediate defensive geography over long-term political reconciliation, Bismarck committed a fatal paradox: he won a tactical border shield but made a permanent, irreconcilable enemy of France, foreclosing any prospect of enduring European stability.

[4.2] The devastating long-term consequence of 1871 was the complete militarization and polarization of continental statecraft. Understanding that France would never forgive the loss of Alsace-Lorraine, Bismarck spent the following twenty years trapped in a perpetual nightmare: the dread of a "two-front war" where France would ally with another great power—most terrifyingly Tsarist Russia—to crush Germany from both east and west. To prevent this, Bismarck was forced to construct an increasingly intricate, fragile web of secret treaties, weaving the Triple Alliance (with Austria-Hungary and Italy in 1882) and the secret Reinsurance Treaty with Russia (1887) to keep France diplomatically isolated. But when the impetuous young Kaiser Wilhelm II dismissed Bismarck in 1890 and reckless Berlin diplomats allowed the Russian treaty to lapse, the inevitable occurred: in 1894, Tsarist Russia and Republican France forged a military alliance. The tragic trap had closed. The hatred forged in the snows of Paris, the black-bordered maps of French classrooms, and the Krupp guns of Sedan guaranteed that when the crisis of 1914 erupted, France would march into the abyss not merely for imperial prestige, but to settle the unfinished business of 1870.

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Of the three penalties forced upon France in the 1871 treaty (loss of land, 5 billion franc fine, German occupation), which do you think caused the most bitter resentment, and why?

Active Tasks

Q2. Did the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine protect Germany or make a future European war inevitable?

Q3. Explain why the Franco-Prussian War created a lasting legacy of hatred between France and Germany.

Q4. Evaluate how the change in leadership from Bismarck to Kaiser Wilhelm II fundamentally altered Germany's strategic position in Europe.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q5. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the reasons for French hatred of Germany after 1871?

"We must never forget the humiliation of 1871. The German Empire was proclaimed in our own Palace of Versailles, tearing away the bleeding wounds of Alsace and Lorraine. They have stolen our iron and our factories, and forced us to pay a crushing ransom of 5 billion francs. Every French child must grow up with one single thought: to rebuild our army and take back what was stolen from the motherland."

Source A: Adapted from a French school textbook, published in Paris, 1885.

"France will never forgive us for taking Alsace-Lorraine. The peace we have forced upon them has left a bitter resentment that will not fade. We must accept that a French war of revenge is a certainty in the future. Therefore, our entire diplomatic focus must be to ensure she never finds an ally to help her take it back. As long as France remains diplomatically isolated, particularly from Russia, Germany will remain secure."

Source B: Adapted from a private letter written by German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck to a fellow diplomat, 1872.

L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the main European colonial powers and their territories.
- ☐ Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's 'Place in the Sun' policy threatened Britain.
- ☐ Evaluate the impact of the Moroccan Crises on the Entente Cordiale.

Do Now Activity (Prior Knowledge Recall)

1. Who was the first Emperor of the newly unified Germany in 1871?
2. Which brilliant Chancellor united the German states?
3. Which country was humiliatingly defeated in the Franco-Prussian War?
4. What strategic border territory did Germany take in 1871?
5. What is the French word for their desire for revenge?
6. Explain how Bismarck used the Ems Telegram to trap France into a war.
7. Detail the two military advantages the Prussian army possessed.
8. Why was the location of the German Empire's proclamation so humiliating for France?
9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?
10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Imperialism | Scramble for Africa | Weltpolitik | Place in the Sun | Entente Cordiale | Algeciras Conference | Agadir Crisis | Gunboat Diplomacy | Berlin Conference | Congo Free State

Power, Governance & Warfare

Economy, Trade & Society

In 1905, Kaiser Wilhelm II sailed to Tangier in Morocco. He backed Moroccan independence against French rule. The Kaiser expected Britain and France to quarrel and split. Instead, his risky gamble backfired. At the 1906 Algeciras Conference, Britain firmly backed France. Germany was left isolated and humiliated. In 1911, the Kaiser sent a German warship to Agadir in Morocco. Once again, Britain stood by France and prepared the Royal Navy for war. The Kaiser's clumsy gunboat diplomacy convinced both nations that Germany was a dangerous threat.

By 1900, European Great Powers were racing to build overseas empires. This fierce race was known as Imperialism. Possessing colonies gave a country great status, wealth, and global power. Every colony provided cheap raw materials to feed European factories. In return, colonies bought European factory goods. In 1884, European leaders met at the Berlin Conference. They divided the African continent among themselves on a map. No African leaders were invited to the meeting. The Congo Free State suffered harsh cruelty under King Leopold II of Belgium.

Great Britain ruled the largest empire in human history. As an island nation, Britain relied entirely on open sea routes. Thousands of British merchant ships sailed the oceans every day. The Royal Navy protected these vital global trade routes from rival fleets. Crucially, Britain controlled the Suez Canal in Egypt. This canal was the vital sea shortcut to India. Any challenge to British naval power was seen as a direct threat to survival. France held the second-largest empire, mainly in North and West Africa. France had lost Alsace-Lorraine to Germany in 1871. French leaders fiercely guarded their colonies to restore national pride. In 1898, Britain and France nearly fought over Sudan during the tense Fashoda Incident.

European peace was shaken when Germany entered the imperial race. Germany had only unified in 1871. However, German factories and steel mills were expanding at unmatched speed. Kaiser Wilhelm II wanted Germany to match the global influence of Britain and France. He launched an ambitious new foreign policy called Weltpolitik. On 6 December 1897, Foreign Secretary Bernhard von Bülow gave a famous speech in parliament. He declared that Germany would no longer stand in the shadows. He boldly demanded Germany's own place in the sun.

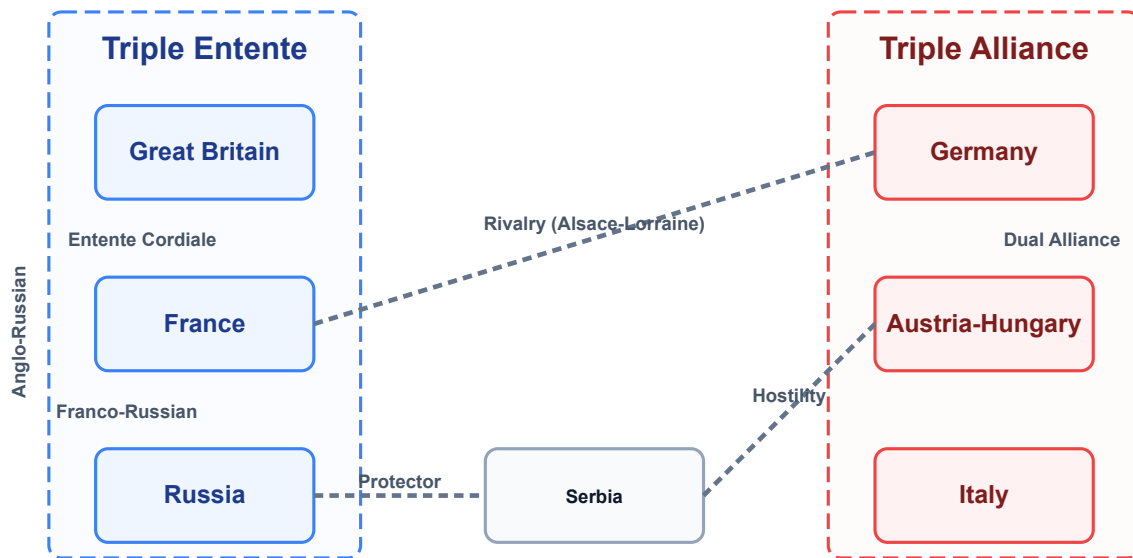
Germany rapidly seized lands across Africa and the Pacific. These colonies included Cameroon, Togo, German East Africa, and Kaiser-Wilhelmsland in New Guinea. However, German leaders wanted an even larger world empire. To protect these distant colonies, Germany began building a huge battle fleet. This naval build-up deeply alarmed Great Britain. British leaders feared Germany wanted to destroy the Royal Navy. Meanwhile, German leaders believed Britain was an arrogant barrier blocking Germany's rightful rise.

In 1904, Britain and France signed a historic treaty called the Entente Cordiale. This agreement settled their old colonial disputes in North Africa. France recognised British rule in Egypt. In return, Britain accepted French influence in Morocco. Kaiser Wilhelm II was furious about this friendly partnership. He feared that Britain and France were plotting to encircle Germany. The Kaiser decided to test the new alliance. He believed Britain would never risk war to defend French interests in North Africa.

In March 1905, the Kaiser arrived in Tangier, Morocco. He rode through the streets on a white horse. Wilhelm announced that he supported the Sultan of Morocco as an independent ruler. He demanded an international conference to settle the Moroccan crisis. The Kaiser hoped to humiliate France and break the Anglo-French friendship. However, his gamble failed completely. At the 1906 Algeiras Conference, Britain strongly supported France. Germany was left isolated, backed only by Austria-Hungary.

In 1911, the Kaiser triggered a second dangerous standoff known as the Agadir Crisis. France sent troops to Morocco to put down a rebellion. Germany claimed this broke the Algeiras agreement. In response, Wilhelm sent a gunboat, the SMS Panther, to the Moroccan port of Agadir. The Kaiser tried to use gunboat diplomacy to bully France into giving up land in the Congo. Britain was furious at this German aggression. Chancellor David Lloyd George warned that Britain would fight rather than let Germany dominate Europe. The Royal Navy was placed on alert for war. Germany backed down in exchange for small strips of swamp in Central Africa. The crisis proved to Britain and France that Germany was an unpredictable and dangerous threat.

The European Alliance System (1914)



Consolidation Task

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. If you were a British politician in 1897, would you view Kaiser Wilhelm's 'Place in the Sun' speech as a direct threat, or just a young leader showing off? Why?

Active Tasks

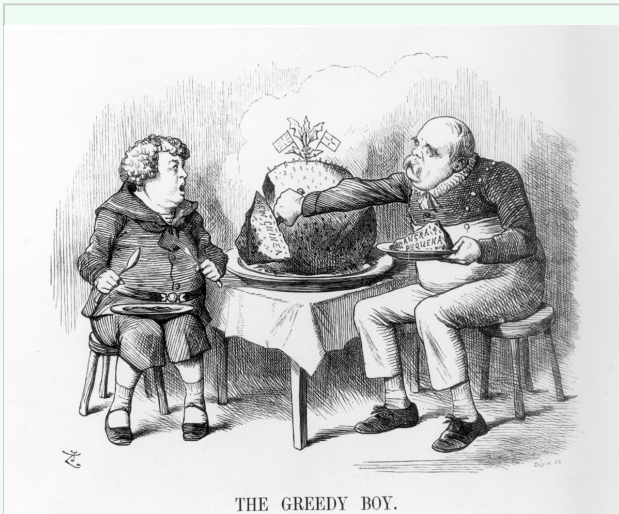
Q2. To what extent did the Scramble for Africa and the Moroccan Crises make war in Europe more likely?

Q3. Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's policy of Weltpolitik and the Moroccan Crises drove Britain and France into a united diplomatic alliance against Germany.

Q4. Explain why Kaiser Wilhelm's strategy of testing the Entente Cordiale during the Moroccan Crises was a massive strategic failure for Germany.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q5. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the impact of Weltpolitik on international relations?



Source A: Source A: 'The Greedy Boy', a British political cartoon published in 1885 showing German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck.

"We do not want to put anyone in the shade, but we too demand our place in the sun."

Source B: Speech by German Foreign Minister Bernhard von Bülow to the Reichstag, 1897.

L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the significance of the HMS Dreadnought.
- ☐ Explain the concept of the Two-Power Standard and Risk Theory.
- ☐ Analyze how naval competition fed mutual suspicion.

Do Now Activity (Prior Knowledge Recall)

1. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?
2. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.
3. Why was the Franco-Russian Alliance a strategic disaster for Germany?
4. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.
5. Describe the impact of Britain abandoning its policy of 'Splendid Isolation'.
6. Evaluate the role of Wilhelm II's personality in destabilizing Europe.
7. Who dismissed Otto von Bismarck in 1890?
8. What strategic territory did Germany take from France in 1871?
9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?
10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:

Naval Supremacy | Two-Power Standard | Arms Race | Dreadnought | German Navy Laws | Navy League | Grand Fleet | High Seas Fleet | Kiel Canal | Scapa Flow

Challenge: Write ONE statement containing a deliberate historical misconception using **Naval Supremacy** or **Two-Power Standard**. Identify and correct the error:

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:

For a century, Great Britain ruled the oceans. The Royal Navy was the strongest fleet on earth. However, in 1898, Kaiser Wilhelm II decided to challenge British sea power. He began building a massive German battle fleet. In 1906, Britain launched a revolutionary warship named HMS Dreadnought. It was faster and more heavily armoured than any ship in history. Yet this super-battleship created an unexpected problem. It made all older battleships obsolete overnight. Britain's massive naval lead was instantly wiped out. Germany could now challenge Britain on equal terms to build dreadnoughts.

Following the Battle of Trafalgar in 1805, Great Britain dominated the world's oceans without challenge. Britain was an island nation with a vast global empire. It relied on naval supremacy to protect trade routes and defend its shores. Britain followed a strict policy called the Two-Power Standard. This rule stated that the Royal Navy must always be as large as the next two biggest navies combined. To British leaders, naval supremacy was essential for national survival.

Everything changed in 1898 when Kaiser Wilhelm II set out to build a powerful German navy. The Kaiser believed Germany required a great battle fleet to become a true world power. In 1898 and 1900, Germany passed the historic German Navy Laws. These laws ordered shipyards to build 19 battleships in the first law and 38 more in the second. Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz directed the build-up. He established the Navy League to build public support. This patriotic league organised shipyard tours and delivered lectures to inspire civilian enthusiasm.

British politicians were deeply alarmed by Germany's naval expansion. They believed the German High Seas Fleet was designed specifically to fight Britain. British leaders pointed out a fundamental difference between the two nations. For Britain, a massive navy was essential to secure food imports and trade. For Germany, a huge standing army already protected its borders on land. A German battle fleet seemed to Britain like a weapon created for war.

Britain responded to the German challenge by designing the ultimate warship. In 1906, Britain launched HMS Dreadnought. The ship possessed thick steel armour and ten heavy 12-inch guns in rotating turrets. It used steam turbine engines to travel faster than any rival battleship. The vessel was so advanced that it made all existing battleships obsolete overnight. However, this wiped out Britain's advantage. Germany immediately began building its own dreadnoughts, beginning with SMS Rheinland. By 1914, Germany had doubled its fleet, becoming the second-largest naval power in the world.

This competitive naval race produced a tense standoff in the North Sea. The British Grand Fleet was stationed at its main base at Scapa Flow in northern Scotland. The German High Seas Fleet was based at Wilhelmshaven on the North Sea coast. Both navies prepared for a huge, decisive sea clash. To move its dreadnoughts rapidly between the Baltic and North Seas, Germany widened the Kiel Canal. This huge project was finished in 1914, just weeks before the outbreak of war.

Before 1906, Britain felt secure behind the Two-Power Standard. German shipyards struggled to match Britain's hundreds of older warships. However, launching HMS Dreadnought accidentally levelled the playing field. Because older warships no longer counted in battle, both empires were forced to restart the race from scratch.

HMS Dreadnought was a triumph of British engineering. Its uniform battery of 12-inch guns could fire at extreme ranges. Its heavy armour resisted enemy shells, and its steam turbines delivered unmatched speed. Yet it contained a fatal strategic flaw. By showing that older warships were useless, Britain made its own huge fleet obsolete.

Germany seized this historic chance at once. The naval competition transformed into a contest to build modern dreadnought-class vessels. German shipyards worked day and night to rival British production. In Britain, alarmed citizens demanded more warships with the famous slogan: 'We want eight and we won't wait!' This bitter naval race drained national budgets and created toxic distrust between Britain and Germany.

Consolidation Task

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Who do you think was more to blame for the naval arms race: Germany for building a fleet they didn't strictly need, or Britain for refusing to share control of the seas?

Active Tasks

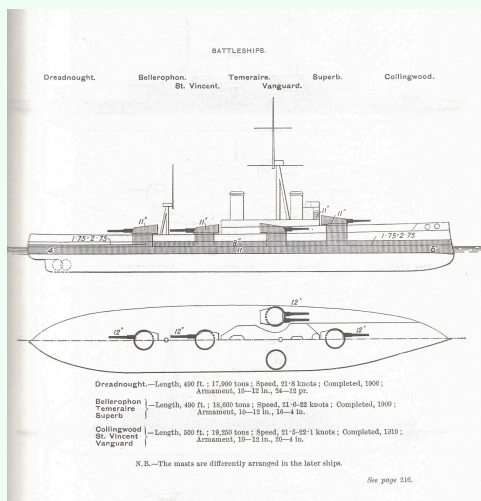
Q2. Why did the building of Dreadnought battleships destroy Anglo-German relations?

Q3. Explain why the Anglo-German naval arms race destroyed diplomatic trust between Great Britain and Germany between 1898 and 1914.

Q4. How did the invention of the HMS Dreadnought ironically endanger British naval supremacy despite being a British invention?

GCSE Exam Practice

Q5. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the effects of the Anglo-German naval arms race?



Source A: Official technical blueprint of HMS Dreadnought, 1906.

"We want eight, and we won't wait!"

Source B: Popular British political slogan chanted by the public in 1909.

L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the members of the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente.
- ☐ Explain why countries felt the need to form secret defensive treaties.
- ☐ Evaluate how the alliance system could drag all of Europe into a regional conflict.

Do Now Activity (Prior Knowledge Recall)

1. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?
2. What was the 'Two-Power Standard'?
3. Why did Germany feel it needed a massive high seas fleet?
4. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.
5. What was the popular British slogan chanted by the public in 1909?
6. Why did Britain feel their survival depended on massive naval supremacy?
7. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?
8. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?
9. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.
10. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Triple Alliance | Triple Entente | Encirclement | Blank Cheque | Schlieffen Plan | Mobilisation |
Armed Camps | Preventative War | Reinsurance Treaty

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

By 1914, Europe was divided into two hostile armed camps. On 5 July 1914, Kaiser Wilhelm II issued the famous 'Blank Cheque' to Austria-Hungary. This was an unconditional promise of total German military backing against Serbia. Historians still debate why Germany gave this reckless promise. Some argue the Kaiser acted out of personal loyalty to his murdered friend. Others argue the German High Command used the crisis to force a war. German generals feared that Russia's army was modernising rapidly. They believed that if war was coming, Germany must strike before Russia grew too strong.

As European empires expanded, rival nations grew suspicious of each other. European leaders looked for ways to protect their borders from sudden attack. Their main strategy was to sign binding military alliances. Over several decades, Europe was carved into two heavily armed, opposing camps. Instead of creating lasting peace, this web of treaties created a dangerous trap.

By 1907, the alliance system had split Europe into two rival groups. On one side stood the Triple Alliance, formed in 1882 by Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. On the opposing side was the Triple Entente, uniting Great Britain, France, and Russia. Diplomats argued that this balance of power would keep the

peace. Their logic was simple. Attacking one nation would trigger an immediate war against all its allies. Leaders believed no country would be foolish enough to start such a terrible conflict.

However, the alliance system bred deep fear rather than safety. German leaders viewed the Triple Entente as a hostile ring designed to encircle Germany. Crucially, military leaders like Austria's Conrad von Hötzendorf believed a European war was inevitable and necessary. German generals feared that Russia was building railways and modernising its army at rapid speed. They believed Germany must fight before Russia became unbeatable. This fear drove the Schlieffen Plan. This plan aimed to defeat France in six weeks before turning east to face Russia.

At the same time, European factories fueled a massive arms race on land. Between 1906 and 1914, German steel production surged to over 17 million tonnes, far outpacing Britain and France. Steel mills forged heavy artillery, machine guns, and millions of rifle shells. Thousands of miles of new railway tracks were laid across Europe. These tracks allowed armies to move hundreds of thousands of troops to the front line in days. Europe had become a powder keg waiting for a single spark.

In July 1914, that spark arrived in the Balkans. Following the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand, Austria-Hungary wanted to crush Serbia. However, Austrian leaders feared that Russia would step in to protect Serbia. To act safely, Austria needed a guarantee of German backing. On 5 July 1914, Kaiser Wilhelm II gave Austria-Hungary the 'Blank Cheque'. This was a promise of unconditional support, even if war broke out with Russia.

The 'Blank Cheque' remains one of the most debated actions in modern history. Some historians argue the Kaiser acted impulsively out of friendship. They note that Wilhelm went on a sailing holiday right after making the promise. This suggests he did not expect a world war to erupt.

However, other historians argue that the German High Command deliberately pushed Austria into war. German generals knew Russia's military was growing stronger every month. If a major European war was inevitable, they wanted to fight it in 1914 rather than wait. By giving Austria unconditional support, Germany ensured the crisis would explode into a total European war.

Consolidation Task

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Imagine you are an ordinary Serbian citizen in 1908. Why would Austria-Hungary's aggressive takeover of Bosnia make you feel personally threatened?

Active Tasks

Q2. Did the alliance system preserve the peace of Europe or make a continental war inevitable?

Q3. Explain how the division of Europe into the Triple Alliance and Triple Entente transformed minor regional disputes into a continental crisis.

Q4. Was the 'Blank Check' a reckless mistake by the Kaiser, or a calculated move by the German military to trigger a necessary war? Use historical reasoning to justify your stance.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q5. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the threat posed by Serbia to Austria-Hungary?



Source A: Map of the Balkans showing the borders of Serbia and the Austro-Hungarian Empire in 1914.

"Serbia is a viper that must be crushed. If we do not destroy them now, our empire will be torn apart by Slavic nationalism."

Source B: Diary entry of the Austro-Hungarian Chief of Staff, Conrad von Hötzendorf, 1913.

L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the events of 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Explain how the assassination triggered the alliance system.
- ☐ Analyze whether the resulting war was inevitable or accidental.

Do Now Activity (Prior Knowledge Recall)

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. Which three countries made up the Triple Entente? | 2. Which three countries made up the Triple Alliance? |
| 3. Explain the theoretical logic of how the alliance system was supposed to keep peace. | 4. Why did the alliance system actually increase paranoia instead of security? |
| 5. What military plan did Germany create to avoid a long two-front war? | 6. Which neutral country did the Schlieffen Plan require invading? |
| 7. What feeling of being surrounded by enemies haunted German planners? | 8. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906? |
| 9. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy. | 10. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely? |

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose *TWO* terms from the word bank. Write *ONE* grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Assassination | Black Hand | Pan-Slavism | Annexation | Ultimatum | July Crisis | Mobilisation | Schlieffen Plan | Treaty of London (1839) | Willy-Nicky Telegrams

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

The Balkans region in south-east Europe was known as the 'powder keg of Europe'. It had long been ruled by the Turkish Ottoman Empire. As Ottoman power weakened, new independent nations emerged. These young Balkan states fought bitter local wars for territory. The area was filled with intense nationalism, ethnic hatred, and military rivalry.

For the neighbouring Austro-Hungarian Empire, Slavic nationalism was a deadly threat. Austria-Hungary was a vast empire made of many different nationalities. Its leaders feared that if Serbia grew strong, the millions of Serbs living inside Austrian borders would rebel. In 1908, Austria caused outrage by annexing Bosnia and Herzegovina. Furious Serbian army officers formed a secret terrorist society called the Black Hand. They swore to unite all South Slavs by force.

By June 1914, Balkan tensions were ready to explode. Archduke Franz Ferdinand was the heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne. He scheduled a royal visit to Sarajevo, the capital of Bosnia. The date was 28 June—a sacred national day for Serbs. The visit was widely reported in newspapers. The Black Hand knew the exact route. Six young assassins lined the riverfront Appel Quay armed with pistols and bombs.

At first, the assassination plot failed completely. One terrorist lost his nerve. Another felt pity and went home. A third threw a grenade that bounced off the royal car and wounded officers behind. Franz Ferdinand was furious. He decided to visit the wounded officers in hospital. However, the driver took a fatal wrong turn onto Franz Josef Street. When the driver realized his error, he stopped the car and tried to reverse.

The open-top car stopped right in front of nineteen-year-old Gavrilo Princip. Seizing his chance, the Black Hand assassin stepped forward. He fired two shots at point-blank range. One bullet hit the Archduke in the neck. The second bullet struck his wife, Sophie, in the stomach. Both died within minutes.

This local double-murder triggered a rapid countdown to world war. Backed by Germany's 'Blank Cheque', Austria-Hungary issued a harsh ultimatum to Serbia. On 28 July 1914, Austria declared war and shelled Belgrade. Russia mobilized its massive army to defend Serbia. Germany then declared war on Russia and France. To invade France quickly, German troops marched into neutral Belgium. Britain had promised to protect Belgium in the 1839 Treaty of London. On 4 August 1914, Britain declared war on Germany.

The 37 days between the Sarajevo murder and the outbreak of war are called the July Crisis. During this tense month, diplomats and rulers scrambled to prevent a catastrophe. The tragic reality of the July Crisis is how close Europe came to stopping the disaster.

The most famous peace effort was the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams'. Kaiser Wilhelm II and Tsar Nicholas II were cousins. They sent urgent, personal telegrams pleading with each other to stop army mobilizations. However, neither monarch dared to halt their troops first. Each feared being left defenseless if the other attacked.

Ultimately, civilian politicians lost control to military generals. War plans like Germany's Schlieffen Plan depended on strict railway timetables. Once mobilization began, the generals insisted it could not be stopped. The alliance system acted like a giant doomsday machine, pulling every Great Power into the abyss.

When war began in 1914, it was never just a European conflict. Because of imperial expansion across Africa and Asia, millions of colonial soldiers were pulled into the fighting. Without the courage and sacrifice of these colonial troops, the European empires could not have fought the war.

The July Crisis (1914) - The Domino Effect



Consolidation Task

Pair & Share Activity

Q1. Look at the timeline of the July Crisis. At which exact moment do you think a world war became completely unstoppable? Was it the assassination, the blank cheque, or the mobilisations?

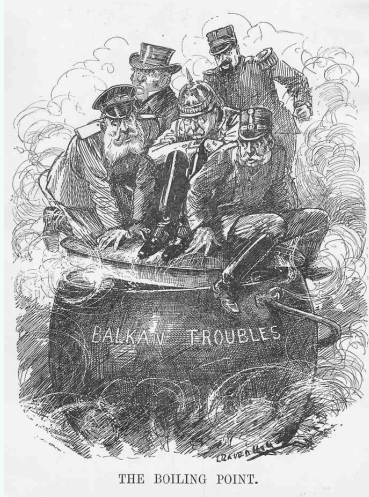
Active Tasks

Q2. Was the outbreak of war in August 1914 caused by individual accidents in Sarajevo or deep structural forces?

Q3. Explain why the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo led directly to the outbreak of the First World War in August 1914.

GCSE Exam Practice

Q4. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the causes of the outbreak of World War I?



Source A: 'The Boiling Point', a British cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1912.

"You may rest assured that His Majesty will faithfully stand by Austria-Hungary, as is required by the obligations of his alliance and of his ancient friendship."

Source B: The 'Blank Cheque' telegram sent from Germany to Austria-Hungary, 5 July 1914.